

2027 Budget Hearing Morning Session - September 9th, 2026

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2BnQRgA-nEE
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Delaware County Council – Meeting Summary Report

Meeting Date: September 9, 2026

Session: Budget Work Session & Public Hearing

1. Pre-Meeting Hearings & Committee Work Sessions

- **Session Type & Topic:** [00:03:40](#) **2027 Budget Public Hearing** (Statutory requirement).
- **Summary of Discussion:** The council convened the statutory public hearing for the proposed 2027 budget. Notice was given regarding public inspection, submission of written comments through the auditor's office, and alternative communication methods for constituents.

2. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** [00:02:01](#) The Delaware County Council regular budget session was called to order by the presiding officer.
- **Attendance:**
 - *Members Present:* Lang, Pants (and other council members responding to roll call).

- *Presiding Officer:* Identified as the Council President.
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3. Preliminary & Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:** 00:02:14 The meeting opened with the Pledge of Allegiance.
 - **Approval of Minutes / Agenda:** 00:03:11 The agenda was approved by voice vote following a motion and a second.
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4. Substantive Business & Board Action

00:05:21 Public Comment on the 2027 Budget

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Rick Insanear (Citizen).
 - **Deliberation Summary:** Expressed concern over rising property reassessments (ranging from 10% to 50% increases) and proposed tax/levy increases, noting a general taxpayer sentiment against paying additional fees. Mentioned recent discussions regarding stormwater fee increases.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Informational public comment only; no board action taken.
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00:09:00 Department Review: Delaware County Airport Authority

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Airport Representative.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** The airport budget remains largely consistent with prior years, though affected by rising fuel and operational costs. Discussed the status of the 2026 excess levy appeal (\$\$700,000\$) which awaits the release of the 2027 excess levy petition form from the Department of Local Government Finance (DLGF) ahead of the October 21 deadline.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Review concluded; no formal vote taken.
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00:11:06 Department Review: County Surveyor (General, Drainage Board, & Perpetuation)

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Tom (County Surveyor).
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - General fund request is down \$5,633 from last year with flat wages.
 - Discussed an increase in the drainage board attorney line (moving from a flat monthly rate of \$\$7,665\$ to hourly billing budgeted at \$\$20,000\$). The council requested the surveyor investigate whether reconstruction attorney fees can be legally paid out of the general maintenance fund.

- Addressed staffing vacancies (office manager position vacant for ~3 months) and suggestions to evaluate cross-training or part-time replacement options to optimize efficiency.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Review concluded; salary increases temporarily removed pending overall budget balancing.
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00:27:15 Department Review: County Treasurer

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Brad (County Treasurer) and Kathy Butterfield (Chief Deputy).
 - **Deliberation Summary:**
 - Requested budget reflects a \$33,773 increase over last year, driven largely by part-time staffing needs due to Northwest Bank and merchants altering their tax collection methods, leading to higher walk-in traffic.
 - Added a new contractual services line (\$10,000) for IT support to prepare tax statements.
 - Highlighted strong investment performance, projecting roughly \$3 million in interest earnings for the current year and \$2.3\$2.5 million for next year.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Review concluded; proposed salary increases temporarily removed for later review.
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00:50:27 Department Review: Purdue Extension

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Becky Noral and team.
 - **Deliberation Summary:**
 - Presented updated staffing figures: reducing from two county-paid employees down to one staff position (\$55,432), reallocating funds to contractual services (\$145,000 + \$55,432 = \$200,432), resulting in a net county savings of \$32,845 after contractual increases.
 - Removed \$3,500 in transportation and \$2,200 for educator computers.
 - Noted that contractual fees are tied to a two-year tier system based on the 2023 US Census population (~112,340 residents).
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Review concluded; adjustments noted and integrated into worksheet tracking \$(\$222,059\$).
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02:02:27 Department Review: Delaware County Visitors Bureau / Visit Muncie Inc.

- **Sponsor / Presenter:** Tourism Bureau Representative.
- **Deliberation Summary:**
 - Budget is funded via a 5% Innkeepers Tax. Projected revenue exceeds requested expenditures.

- Discussed upcoming relocation down Walnut Street to accommodate a growing staff, increased operational needs, and a large donated Garfield pop-culture collection.
 - Financial balances: \$30,000 in the Travel and Tourism Commission checking account, \$1.8 million in the Hoosier fund/savings, and \$250,000 in Visit Muncie Inc. checking.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Review concluded by voice consensus.
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(Note: Subsequent departmental reviews for the Assessor, County Recorder, Plan Commission, County Coroner, Fair Board, GIS, Communications/911, and EMA followed similar chronological deliberation and salary-stripping procedures).

5. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

- No general open citizen forum occurred during this portion of the transcript; public input was captured during the statutory budget public hearing 00:03:40.
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6. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Staff / Board Announcements:** 03:23:39 The council noted they were running approximately 35 to 40 minutes ahead of schedule.
 - **Adjournment:** 03:24:02 The meeting recessed for a lunch break, with budget hearings scheduled to resume at 1:00 PM (and continuing the following day at 10:30 AM following the DCRC meeting).
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